

Dividends of DIVISION

A separate Telangana should be the first step towards the reorganisation of states based on regional and economic aspirations

| By Amarnath K. Menon |

Call it Gandhian blackmail or the last desperate measure of a man who valued the idea of a separate Telangana state more than his life. It worked. The Union Home Minister had to make a dramatic mid-night announcement that India's fourth largest state would eventually be divided, though not so explicitly. Telangana is still a far cry but Telangana Rashtra Samiti (TRS) leader K. Chandrasekhara Rao's thwarted martyrdom has made the cause of the small state a national war cry. And it may very well result in the remapping of India—for the better.

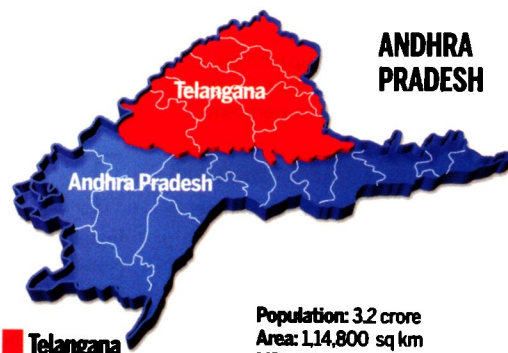
Obviously, the mergers or divisions on the simplistic criterion of a common language have outlived their utility in drawing state boundaries. As the identifying and sharing of resources like water becomes inevitable, there seems to be only one viable option: a Second States Reorganisation Commission that carves out areas based on holistic and rational norms. It is no longer about language but regional aspirations, political as well as economic. "The issue is not whether development has been taking place but the rate and quality or pattern of development. Apart from equity, such

as due share in investment allocations, quality also includes the cost, risks, and sustainability of development," says renowned economist and former Planning Commission member C. Hanumantha Rao.

The last exercise in creating small states—Chhattisgarh, Jharkhand and Uttarakhand by the BJP-led NDA in 2000—has worked, though the storylines are not similar, and decadal analysis of development indices of the compact regions reveal they perform better than the larger ones if they have or get adequate resources. Their experience has been extremely encouraging in the growth in Gross State Domestic Product (GSDP). According to the 11th Plan document, approved by the National Development Council, these three

states have achieved growth rates far exceeding the targets set for the 10th Plan period whereas the performance of their parent states—Madhya Pradesh, Bihar and Uttar Pradesh—fell considerably short. Chhattisgarh achieved a growth rate of 9.2 per cent as against a target of 6.1 per cent a year, Jharkhand notched 11.1 per cent while it was expected to show 6.9 per cent and Uttarakhand achieved 8.8 per cent when the target was 6.8 per cent.

And statistics like this explains why the campaign for statehood articulates the demand for a fair share in resources. "These high growth rates in GSDP lend credence to the proposition that the growth potential of these backward areas remained suppressed for long and their constitu-



■ Telangana

Districts: 10

Hyderabad Adilabad
Ranga Reddy Nizamabad
Medak Warangal
Nalgonda Karimnagar
Khammam Mahabubnagar

Population: 3.2 crore
Area: 1,14,800 sq km
MPs: 17

Economy: It is rich in coal and limestone deposits, pharmaceutical, IT and allied service sector industries. But it has large tracts of semi-arid land with low agricultural productivity.

